



sequences of moves.

After the two decisive results inside the first three days of the match, the players had their first rest day. The scores were equal. And one thing was clear: the match was going to be evenly fought. It was not going to be an 80-20 situation for Gukesh, as Nakamura said, nor even 75-25, as another top American Grandmaster, Wesley So, said, with weeks remaining for the match.

What followed was equality. Quite literally.

The next seven games were all drawn. But some of those were quite thrilling affairs. **And there was one pattern: while Ding seemed happy to get into a theoretically drawn position most of the time, his young rival wasn't.** Gukesh even rejected the virtual offers of a draw by refusing to make the move that would allow a threefold repetition in positions and thus a draw. That seemed like another strategy. Gajewski later admitted it was indeed part of the strategy.

The string of draws was broken by Gukesh in Game 11. He scored an easy win, capitalising on Ding's errors. And he was in the lead — for the first time in the match.

A year ago, in his World championship match against Nepomniachtchi, the only time Ding was in the lead was when he won in the tiebreaks after the classical games finished with scores level. The theme of Astana was Ding's fightback: three times he had been behind Nepomniachtchi, and three times he came back to equalise.

So it was almost inevitable that he did it at Sentosa, too. And he did, outplaying Gukesh in Game 12. It was a masterclass by Ding. It was the World champion at work.

The last rest day of the championship followed. Now just two games remained. A player needed to score 1.5 points (a win and a draw) if he wanted to win the title without going through the tiebreakers. In Game 13, Gukesh had a chance to force a win, but he

Guiding light: Paddy Upton, one of the top mental coaches in international sport, was instrumental in D. Gukesh's World Chess Championship victory, adding to his successes with India's 2011 Cricket World Cup winning team and the 2024 Paris Olympics hockey bronze. FIDE/MARIA EMELIANOVA

missed a crucial move. Then Ding, whose defence had been incredibly strong, found the only move to save his position in severe time pressure. It wasn't the first time that Ding was successfully impersonating Houdini.

In the final game too, Ding was doing what he had been doing all along: defending. But on the 55th move, he erred, fatally, with his rook. Gukesh didn't. His rook captured Ding's. It was all over now.

Three moves later, Ding surrendered his kingdom. His king faced checkmate.

Gukesh was now the king. And the king wept in joy.